

the receptacle excavated by Nitocris, when she made the stone piers of the bridge within the town.² Xenophon records a tradition that it was by means of two new cuttings of his own, from a point of the river above the city to a point below it.³ Both agree that he entered the city by the channel of the Euphrates, and that he waited for a general festival which was likely to engage the attention of the inhabitants, before turning the stream from its natural bed.⁴ If the sinking of the water had been observed, his plan would have been frustrated by the closing of the city water-gates, and his army would have been caught, as Herodotus expresses it, "in a trap."⁵

25. The city was taken at the extremities long ere the inhabitants of the central parts had a suspicion of their danger. Then it may well be that "one post ran to meet another, and one messenger to meet another, to show the king of Babylon that his city was taken at one end."⁶ According to Berosus, indeed, Nabonadius was not in Babylon, but at Borsippa, at the time when Babylon was taken, having fled to that comparatively unimportant city when his army was defeated in the field.⁷ He seems, however, to have left in Babylon a representative in the person of his son, whom a few years previously he had associated with him in the government. This prince, whose name is read as *Bil-shar-uzur*, and who may be identified with the Belshazzar of Daniel,⁸ appears to have taken the command in the city when Nabonadius threw himself, for some unexplained reason, into Borsippa, which was undoubtedly a strong fortress, and was also one of the chief seats of Chaldæan learning,⁹ but which assuredly could not compare, either for magnificence or for strength, with Babylon. Belshazzar, who was probably a mere youth, left to enjoy the supreme power without check or control, neglected the

² Herod. i. 191.

³ Xen. Cyrop. vii. v. 10.

⁴ Herod. l. s. c.; Xen. Cyrop. vii. v. 15.

⁵ *Ὡς ἐν κύρτῃ.*

⁶ Jer. li. 31.

⁷ *Ναβόννηδος ἡττηθεὶς τῇ μάχῃ συνεκλείσθη εἰς τὴν Βορσιππητὴν πόλιν* (ap. Joseph. contr. Ap. i. 21).

⁸ Ch. v. Two difficulties still stand in the way of this identification, which (if accepted) solves one of the most intricate problems of ancient history. The first is the relationship in which the Belshazzar of Scripture stands to Nebuchadnezzar, which is throughout represented as that of son (verses 2, 11, 13, 18, &c.); the second is the accession, immediately after Belshazzar, of "Darius the Mede." With respect to the first of these, it may be remarked that although Nabonadius was not a descendant, or indeed any relation, of Nebuchadnezzar, Belshazzar may have been, and very probably was. Nabu-nahit, on seizing the supreme power, would naturally seek to strengthen his position by marriage with a daughter of the great king, whose son, son-in-law, and grandson had successively held the throne. He may have taken to wife Neriglissar's widow, or he may have married some other daughter of Nebuchadnezzar. Belshazzar may thus have been grandson of Nebuchadnezzar *on the mother's side*. It is some confirmation of these probabilities, or possibilities, to find that the name of Nebuchadnezzar was used as a family name by Nabu-nahit. He must certainly have had a son to whom he gave that appellation, or it would not have been assumed by two pretenders in succession, who sought to personate the legitimate heir of the Babylonian throne.

On the difficulty presented by the reign of Darius the Mede in Babylon, some remarks have already been made in the Essay, "On the Great Median Empire" (Essay iii. § 11).

⁹ Strab. xvi. p. 1050. Strabo also says that it was famous for its manufacture of linen.